

Swift Report

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COVER STORY

The Power of Assumption

(First real Lesswrong post! Wow.

ysamuels · LessWrong

This is a post on an idea I thought might be interesting to some people here, and I'd love to hear thoughts on it.)

Assumption can be used as a communicative tool.

As a kid I would occasionally, before falling asleep, lie in bed and imagine that I had a very good friend to talk to, or who could cheer me on. Sometimes these were characters from my favorite books, but apparently at some point it occurred to me that presumably someone, somewhere, could be supposed to have anticipated someone else in the world feeling that way at some point, and might actually have wanted to send that someone a message of comfort, love, or support. At this point, all I had to do was imagine roughly what they might say, consider it to be said, and the message would have been received. To put it differently, I was aware that many, probably most, of the people in the world, knowing that I felt lonely, might have wanted to send me their blessings or support, and that presumably, at least one person who felt that way, over all space and time, probably realized that he could send me that message, provided I was smart enough to realize he might try to.

So I could "communicate" with people, when the purpose was therapeutic in that way - I couldn't actually receive ideas I couldn't have thought of myself (by definition), but when it was the communication itself and not the words that mattered, I could receive the messages left for me by people who had found this mental space that was created by the assumption that others would. If I wanted to give as well as receive, I could "leave" messages too, for any future or past thinker, lonely or otherwise, to assume exist. Despite the obvious drawback of not being able to receive any idea you couldn't have thought of yourself, this communication does allow you to completely bypass constraints of language, time and space.

Assumption is famously used in problems where the goal is to meet with someone over varying areas when you have

no (other) mode of communication. I personally had idly wondered for some years what the best way to meet with someone spoken to by assumption would be (assuming they had also considered the possibility of meeting). I remained stuck for quite some time wondering whether it was the Eiffel Tower or the Empire State Building that would be the best place to go at midnight, January first, with a big sign reading "You know why you're here. Talk to me", before realizing that the appropriate place on the internet was probably a much more logical rendezvous (thought that is not the main motive for me in writing here - I've wanted to contribute to LessWrong for some time now).

Just as another point of thought, communication through assumption could in theory be used to create intellectual taboos or norms among intelligent people, for example an accepted and implicit censoring of certain ideas or beliefs that could be realized by anyone smart enough to arrive at them as being unsuitable for spreading (I really hope this isn't one of those).

So:

1. Do you know anyone who has beaten me to writing about this? Please direct me to the source if so. (I hope not, but I do hope it has been thought about before, otherwise I've been played for quite a fool).
2. Do you think this idea is worth anything? Other than game theory, in what other fields or ways could it be used?
3. Have I ever spoken to you telepathically before? If so, please write. That could be a very interesting conversation.

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FEATURES

Keypress is bananas

Monica Dinculescu

The keypress event works maddeningly differently in Chrome/Safari and Firefox, and this is the story of how I spent two hours discovering that, so that hopefully you don't have to.

```
id="keypress-what">Keypress what?
```

A keypress event is one of the events you get when you mash on the keyboard. It's special because according to the spec, you should only get a keypress event for keystrokes that produce printable characters. So you'll get it for things like letters and symbols, but not for backspace and left arrow.

It's a great event to have if you want to write some as-you-type validation on an input, and you want to be able to dismiss the non-printable characters (which will still generate key events, but are uninteresting to the validation bit).

Chrome, Safari and IE10 agree with this interpretation, which is great news.

To be contrarian, Firefox (38; I don't know about Aurora) always sends a keypress event for anything you type. It's basically a keydown event from what I see. Now you have to get rid of control characters yourself and you get write code that doesn't make sense on the other platforms! Yay! (not yay)

I call shenanigans.

```
id="mind-your-keycodes-and-charcodes">Mind your key-  
Codes and charCodes
```

From looking at the spec, we expect a keypress event to have:

`keyCode`, a number code that represents the key you've pressed. For example, `q` is 113. This is allegedly deprecated, but don't worry, both Firefox and Chrome implement it, but differently.

`charCode`, the unicode number of the key. This code only exists for keypress. Like before, it's deprecated, but like before, it's implemented by both browsers. Differently.

`key`, the value of the key represented by the event. According to that spec, this one is unimplemented. Worry not, Firefox implements it just fine (Chrome doesn't). It is the hero we deserve, but not the one we get right now.



What you get out of this is spectacularly annoying. I wrote some code that basically prints out what the keypress event looks like, and found:

As promised, in Chrome/Safari/IE10, we only get the keypress event for printable things. The event always has the

same values for `keyCode` and `charCode`, and doesn't have a `key`.

In Firefox, you get the keypress event for ALL the things, BUT:

for printable characters, `keyCode = 0`, and `charCode` has a sane value.

for control characters, `charCode = 0`, and `keyCode` has a sane value.

this is super because if you've been testing on the other browsers and have been using `String.fromCharCode()`, you're going to get hilariously bad results if you use the wrong code. Like how arrow left could actually be `%`.

see how `key` is kind of nice though? One day, at a browser near you.

There, now you know. And knowing is half the battle.

```
id="ps">P. S.
```

If you read this in the future and the future doesn't work like I said it does, either I was wrong (highly likely), or someone fixed something. Let me know and I can make updates.

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Week 11

Monica Dinculescu

It's been another week of people being shit, innit? I know I should be

used to this by now, but it never ceases to amaze me the capability people have for violence

and evil, and the capability the patriarchy has to excuse it. "Dude had a bad day"? For real real?

If that excuse has legs then you'd expect every uterus-holding person to do at LEAST a murder

per year. And yet it's always white dudes who haven't ever thrown up from cramps or had to deal with birth control hormones that feel they're

entitled to attention or sex or whatever and go on these racist murder sprees. And they're

going to continue to as long as the media excuses them as "bad days", or gives them a platform by

encouraging racism and xenophobia. If you're a Fox news anchor who's ever said the

words "china virus" in the last year...these murders are on you pal. I see you, and I deeply hope you don't have a good night of sleep for the rest of your life.

I took all this anger and donated to Red Canary Song and also pointlessly stabbed linoleum with it. The goal is to carve things a computer generates, but at the moment that's a bit too hard for me (I make the computer generate a lot of lines and uhhh that's a lot of cutting), so I've been carving some non-generative stuff. They're all a bit surrealist, because that is extremely my shit, but I don't really know what to do with them.

I also don't understand my audience. For example, I made this computer plant. I thought it was meh, so I wasn't gonna put it up in the store, but after tweeting about it, it ended up selling out in a nanosecond. I made this March Madness basketball beet that's like...actually well carved and in two colours and cute and nobody cared. The same happened with the generative stuff – the chaos attractors I thought were deeply boring sold out instantly, the wings in flight that I absolutely adore are a no-op. I don't get it, y'all.

I am back on my procedural bullshit. Adam has been telling me about the Mentalist for months now, and holy shit: he was right. A++ procedural murders, be back in 7 seasons.

Every year I say I'm going to do a March Madness bracket where I ignore the chalk and just pick it on names and mascots, and every year I think the chalk knows best so I don't and get busted on like day 1. I see you Oral Roberts toothpastes and Loyola wolf boys, I should've kept you going to the final 4 like I wanted to, eh?

Related: defensive fouls in basketball are absolutely bull-shit.

Zach and I are rewatching all of the Marvel movies in story chronological order. This means that I went on several really productive 4 am YouTube holes of watching Avengers bloopers, every recorded interview with Robert Downey Jr, and that whole Ally McBeal season he was on. Imagine if I could put that kind of energy in watching videos about quantum mechanics or something. Instead, I can tell you that he met his wife when filming Gothika, that Tom Hiddleston couldn't stop laughing during that one scene in Avengers 1 when Hulk smashes him into the Stark tower apartment floor, and that Mark Ruffalo is scared of needles so he doesn't have the Avengers tattoo everyone else got. WHY AM I THIS WAY.

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Week 30: this little drummer girl

Monica Dinculescu

On Monday Frances took me to the teamLab exhibition at the Asian Art museum. It was really wonderful! I hadn't seen the one in Japan so I was new to it, but the interactive art nerd in me was all over the concept and trying to figure out what was static and what was interactive, and where the sensors were. Tons of fun!

On the weekend we went to the Gold Cup ¼ final in Vegas. This is important only because: the powers that be let me bring my own drum and I drummed for the whole 120 minutes. As I might have mentioned this has been a dream of mine, and I'm 100% that dream-believe-achieve bitch. I still need to improve a lot, and bless Ryan (who played the big boi drum next to me) who had to put up with me coming in sliiiightly too early a lot. Only up from here!

Looking at my calendar, a lot of my funemployment is spent levelling up. This will not shock anyone but: I kind of loved school. My first 2 years in uni I audited like 2 or 3 extra classes a semester, because I'd get all the bits I loved (going to class, learning things, taking notes), and none of the existential dread and panic attacks of being evaluated. So now that I'm an adult who gets to control how I learn things, I'm all over it. Here's what's currently on the docket:

Practicing drum rudiments on my snare drum. I should probably find a human to pay to help me with this, since I'm figuring it all out from YouTube and tbh, I have some questions.

Singing classes. I really enjoy singing in the car but I a) don't like the sound of my voice and b) don't actually like to produce loud sounds that draw attention to me, both of which make me not want to sing along in front of people. A lot of singing is relearning how to breathe, and that is Extremely Weird.

Spanish on Duolingo. I used to speak it as a kid (I used to watch a lot of telenovelas, and I'm a bit of a language sponge), but I lost it since I never actually used it. I want to be able to speak to my friend's Colombian family when we go to their wedding, so here I am.

Conversational French hangouts on italki. French and I have a super uncomfortable relationship where after 11 years in Montreal I understand and can read most of it, but I'm unable to speak it. It's not that I don't know what to say, it's that I literally panic and refuse to say the words. I've had a lot of kind of traumatic experiences with a bunch of french (and quebécois) native speakers who were really hostile to people who speak French poorly, and it left me a bit terrified of even trying. I figured the best I can do to work on it is pay a complete stranger to talk to me – even if they think I'm shit, I won't ever see them in person. I will be able to sleep at night just fine.

Books: I am struggling with Homegoing by Yaa Gyasi, because it's a devastating book. It's well written and I des-

perately want to finish, but I find myself dreading reading it; all the stories are about horrible things that people did to slaves and my heart just breaks on every page.

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standard-article(title: [Hello magenta], author: [Monica Dinculescu], source-name: [Monica Dinculescu], images: (), paragraphs: ([Magenta.js is a JavaScript library that helps you generate art and music on the web. It's also the team that I work on now! One of the things that I do whenever I join a new team is learn a bunch of things, and then make a bunch of tutorials that past Monica would've loved to stumble over. This is one of them!], [In this tutorial, we'll talk about the music generation bits in @magenta/music (one of the several libraries in Magenta.js) – how to make your browser sing, and in particular, how to make your browser sing like you !. The tutorial is interactive, and introductory and on Glitch . Go play with all the examples, and have fun! ☺],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 121, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [Drone Wars], author: [Throughline (NPR)], source-name: [Throughline (NPR)], images: (), paragraphs: ([Unseen, they stalk their targets from thousands of feet in the air. Operators are piloting them from military bases halfway across the world. At any moment, they could launch a strike that comes without warning. The attack drone was supposed to be a symbol of the era of precision warfare — a way to wage wars with fewer casualties on both sides. It's a technology that's been honed since it was first dreamed up during World War 1. But are drones actually precise enough? Do drones desensitize us to the casualties of civilians caught between us and our enemies? In this episode, we will explore the past, present and future of drone warfare.], [To manage podcast ad preferences, review the links below:], [See pcm.adswizz.com for information about our collection and use of personal data for sponsorship and to manage your podcast sponsorship preferences.], [Learn more about sponsor message choices: podcastchoices.com/adchoices], [NPR Privacy Policy],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 153, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

brief-group(([

Oisin Kuhnke, Rock Paper Shotgun: I'm going to say it: bullet hells are more stressful than Souls-likes. Why are there 10,000 orbs approaching me, promising me misery and death! And I have to both tactfully dodge them while also staging a front myself? The visual information alone is enough to deteriorate the mind, memorising a list of attack patterns from some big dude with a sword seems like chump change by comparison. So this leaves me quite sweet on DeeSicks, a roguelike take on the game with physics-based dice rolling where god has died and you become your own boss.

[Read more](#)

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Throughline (NPR), Throughline (NPR): What can and can't the president do, and how do we know? When the framers of the U. S. constitution left vague the powers of the executive branch they opened the door to every president to decide how much power they could claim. This week, how the office of the presidency became more powerful than anything the Founding Fathers imagined possible.

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Iman Ganji, Bahar Noorizadeh, n+1 Magazine: The ongoing uprising is rooted in the political economy of structural adjustment, which forms the unstable medium through which revolt becomes contagious.

], [

Oisin Kuhnke, Rock Paper Shotgun: It's been a little over a year since the release of Wanderstop , the debut game of Ivy Road, itself a studio made up of Stanley Parable, Gone Home , and Minecraft talent. Since then, the developer has been trying to find funding for its next game, Engine Angel , but in January announced that this had been unsuccessful , with layoffs taking place as a result. Now, the studio has announced that it is, unfortunately, shutting down.

[Read more](#)

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Mark Warren, Rock Paper Shotgun: Around the turn of the new year, Fallout: London developers Team FOLON teased plans to drop the second of the brilliantly British Fallout 4 mod's second DLC in early 2026, assuming no hiccups got in the way of those plans. Sadly, it seems that's exactly what's happened, necessitating the "skeletal crew" still working on the mod to push Last Orders beyond a projected April release window.

[Read more](#)

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Sam Dembling, n+1 Magazine: We are near an old strain of folk utopianism, one that depicts the afterlife as a place with towers of food rising to the heavens. One of the first songs Hurley came up with was a sort of mantra he and his brother would chant aloud as children: "There's such a thing as doughnuts / In the wide, wide world / Doughnuts! Doughnuts!"

], [

Mark Krotov, n+1 Magazine: Some of Trump's voters—namely the rich and the superrich—will get exactly what they wanted out of the deal. Most will not.

], [

Throughline (NPR), Throughline (NPR): When a cook who carried typhoid fever refused to stop working, despite showing no symptoms, the authorities forcibly quarantined her for nearly three decades. Perfect villain or just a woman scapegoated because of her background? What the story of Typhoid Mary tells us about journalism, the powers of the state, and the tension between personal responsibility and personal liberty.

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n+1 Magazine, n+1 Magazine: On Monday, September 9, join n+1 senior writer Richard Beck in conversation with former n+1 coeditor Nikil Saval at McNally Jackson's South Street Seaport location in Manhattan. They'll be discussing Beck's new book, *Homeland: The War on Terror in American Life*, which is out in Septem-

ber from Crown and available for preorder from the n+1 [...]

], [

Nelson Elhage, Nelson Elhage: A while back, I was poking around LLVM bugs, and discovered, to my surprise, that LLVM doesn't support the `va_arg` intrinsic, used by functions to accept multiple arguments, at all on amd64. It turns out that clang and llvm-gcc, the compilers that backend to LLVM, have their own implementations in the frontend, so this isn't as big a deal as it might sound, but it was still a surprise to me.

],))

standard-article(title: [The Shadows of the Constitution (2020)], author: [Throughline (NPR)], source-name: [Throughline (NPR)], images: (), paragraphs: ([The Constitution is like America's secular bible, our sacred founding document. In her play, What the Constitution Means to Me, Heidi Schreck goes through a process of discovering what the document is really about – who wrote it, who it was for, who it protected and who it didn't. Through Heidi's personal story, we learn how the Constitution and how it has been interpreted have affected not just her family but generations of Americans.], [To manage podcast ad preferences, review the links below:], [See pcm.adswizz.com for information about our collection and use of personal data for sponsorship and to manage your podcast sponsorship preferences.], [Learn more about sponsor message choices: podcastchoices.com/adchoices], [NPR Privacy Policy],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 114, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [Crimson Desert might be an open world jumble of loose ends, but I can't resist its sexy towers and ghost trains], author: [Mark Warren], source-name: [Rock Paper Shotgun], images: (), paragraphs: ([Phwoar, look at that striking steeple on the horizon, I thought after arriving in Crimson Desert 's first town.], [I was playing a man I was fairly sure I couldn't give a toss about , embroiled in a conflict I also couldn't give a toss about, but that tower . Man, it took my breath away. Who could dwell within it? Who first built it? Can I climb it? Where did they get all of that stone? These questions buzzed around my belfry-addled brain. 'Hey, stay on track,' argued another bit of my grey matter, 'you've got a train to find'. 'Train can wait,' I replied, 'must take in the visual majesty of this faraway tower and maybe visit it to see if there's anything interesting to do there'.], [Read more],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 131, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [A History of Zionism], author: [Throughline (NPR)], source-name: [Throughline (NPR)], images: (), paragraphs: ([Since October 7th, the term Zionism has been everywhere in the news. It's been used to support Israel in what it calls its war against Hamas:

standard-article(title: [I was the untitled goose in Big Walk, the balmy new open world co-op puzzler from House House], author: [Edwin Evans-Thirlwell], source-name: [Rock Paper Shotgun], images: (), paragraphs: ([House House were kind enough to keep a video of my hands-on session with Big Walk , filmed by one of the participating PRs. Generally, a full video of a preview event including player audio is a lifesaver for a journalist, struggling to keep notes while pushing buttons. But in this case, I don't want to watch the Big Walk video, because then I would hear what the other players were saying when I wasn't there.], [You see, I fell down a cliff midway through Big Walk, and spent the night floundering about in the ocean. Eventually, a developer armed with a big, ball-shaped lamp tracked me down and ushered me back up, hoisting me onto his shoulders so that I could leap to a rock. Nights in Big Walk last moments. I was gone for the length of a luxurious toilet break. But still, those were moments in which the others were gathered, waiting for me. Perhaps they were making fun of me. I don't want to know.], [Read more],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 171, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [The X On The Map], author: [Throughline (NPR)], source-name: [Throughline (NPR)], images: (), paragraphs: ([In 1965, Jimmie Lee Jackson was an unarmed black civil rights activist who was murdered in Marion, Ala., after a peaceful protest. His murder brought newfound energy to the civil rights movement, leading to the march to Montgomery that ended in "Bloody Sunday." This week, we share an episode we loved from White Lies as they look for answers to a murder that happened more than half a century ago.], [To manage podcast ad preferences, review the links below:], [See pcm.adswizz.com for information about our collection and use of personal data for sponsorship and to manage your podcast sponsorship preferences.], [Learn more about sponsor message choices: podcastchoices.com/adchoices], [NPR Privacy Policy],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 110, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [The Rules of War], author: [Throughline (NPR)], source-name: [Throughline (NPR)], images: (), paragraphs: ([International courts investigating alleged war crimes have made headlines often in recent months. An arrest warrant has been issued for Russian President

a refrain to remind everyone why Israel exists and why it must be protected. Others have used Zionism to describe what they view as Israel's collective punishment of civilians in Gaza, and its appropriation of Palestinian territories — what they often call “settler colonialism.” Zionism has been defined and redefined again and again, and the definitions are often built on competing historical interpretations. So unsurprisingly, we've received many requests from you, our audience, to explore the origins of Zionism. On today's episode, we go back to the late 19th century to meet the people who organized the modern Zionist movement.], [Correction: An earlier version of this episode incorrectly described Ze'ev Jabotinsky as a right-wing settler who helped form the paramilitary organization the Irgun. Jabotinsky was a conservative Zionist thinker whose ideas influenced some of the founders of the Irgun. While Jabotinsky did advocate Jewish settlement in Palestine, he himself lived mostly in Europe and died before Israel's founding.], [To access bonus episodes and listen to Throughline sponsor-free, subscribe to Throughline+ via Apple Podcasts or at plus.npr.org/throughline.], [To manage podcast ad preferences, review the links below:], [See pcm.adswizz.com for information about our collection and use of personal data for sponsorship and to manage your podcast sponsorship preferences.], [Learn more about sponsor message choices: podcastchoices.com/adchoices], [NPR Privacy Policy],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 241, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

Correction: An earlier version of this episode incorrectly described Ze'ev Jabotinsky as a right-wing settler who helped form the paramilitary organization the Irgun.

Throughline (NPR)

standard-article(title: [Crimson Desert can perform well on PC, but you'll need to win its crash lottery first], author: [James Archer], source-name: [Rock Paper Shotgun], images: (), paragraphs: ([The words “consensus” and “RPS treehouse” are normally alien to one another, as is apparent from all the blood splatter on every new RPS 100 . Yet among those of us who've been playing open world everything-em-up Crimson Desert , an agreement has formed that its vastness – its 150-odd gigabytes of ideas, mechanics, and sheer maximalist fantasy – can too easily feel unwieldy.], [To a degree, the same is true of its PC performance. It's not bad , and often balances its gleaming visuals with smooth framerates quite well. Good support for new (but not too new) flavours of DLSS and FSR , as well. It's also prone to instability and inconsistency, and while it's positively receptive to the right settings changes, even this requires navigating through some confusingly labelled upscaling options and possibly the most unusual implementation of ray tracing – or, more specifically, Ray Reconstruction – in all of PC gamedom.], [Read more],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 157, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

Vladimir Putin; arrest warrants have also been requested for senior Hamas and Israeli officials, including Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and Hamas leader Ismail Haniyeh.], [What are these courts, where did they come from, and how did they come to decide the rules of war?], [On today's episode, we travel from the battlefields of the U. S. Civil War, through the rubble of two world wars, to the hallways of the Hague, to trace modern attempts to define and prosecute war crimes.], [To manage podcast ad preferences, review the links below:], [See pcm.adswizz.com for information about our collection and use of personal data for sponsorship and to manage your podcast sponsorship preferences.], [Learn more about sponsor message choices: podcastchoices.com/adchoices], [NPR Privacy Policy],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 143, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [When Things Fall Apart (Throwback)], author: [Throughline (NPR)], source-name: [Throughline (NPR)], images: (), paragraphs: ([Climate change, political unrest, random violence: modern society can often feel like what the filmmaker Werner Herzog calls “a thin layer of ice on top of an ocean of chaos and darkness.” In the United States, polls indicate that many people believe law and order is the only thing protecting us from the savagery of our neighbors. This idea is often called “veneer theory.” But is it true?], [To manage podcast ad preferences, review the links below:], [See pcm.adswizz.com for information about our collection and use of personal data for sponsorship and to manage your podcast sponsorship preferences.], [Learn more about sponsor message choices: podcastchoices.com/adchoices], [NPR Privacy Policy],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 108, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

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